

RESEARCH

Mothering experiences in prison: Exploring distinctions between maternal and paternal caregiving arrangements

Amber Wilson¹ | Barbara Koons-Witt² | Nicola Pasquire²

¹Department of Political Science, University of Wisconsin–Eau Claire, Eau Claire, WI

²Department of Criminology and Criminal Justice, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC

Correspondence

Amber Wilson, Department of Political Science, University of Wisconsin–Eau Claire, Hibbard Humanities Hall 401, 124 Garfield Avenue, Eau Claire, WI 54701 USA.
 Email: wilsoam@uwec.edu

Funding information

Social Sciences Grant Program at the University of South Carolina

Abstract

Objective: The current study considers the mothering experiences of incarcerated women to identify important differences between maternal and paternal caregivers and explore how these arrangements influence mother–child relationships.

Background: Many incarcerated mothers decide who will care for minor children in their absence, often depending on relatives to care for children. Researchers have not yet explored the differential experiences of incarcerated mothers whose children are cared for by maternal and paternal caregivers.

Method: This study uses semistructured interviews with incarcerated mothers. Researchers engaged in thematic and comparative analyses to identify differences in maternal and paternal mother–caregiver dyads.

Results: Mothers whose children lived with maternal caregivers received support from caregivers and were afforded co-parenting opportunities. In contrast, mothers whose children lived with paternal caregivers experienced limited information sharing and attempts to exclude them from parental decision-making.

Conclusion: Mothers highlighted the importance of their maternal mother–caregiver relationships, as well as their mother–child relationships. With less support from paternal caregivers, mothers depended on maternal relatives to serve as an intermediary or resigned themselves to temporarily suspending their maternal role.

Author note: This research was conducted through the cooperation of the South Carolina Department of Corrections (SCDC). The data used for this article were collected as part of a project funded by the Social Sciences Grant Program at the University of South Carolina (UofSC). The views and statements contained within this paper are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect those of the funding organization (UofSC) or the cooperating agency (SCDC).

Implications: Prisons can promote positive mother–caregiver relationships by providing counseling and can support mother–child relationships through various contact programs. Parent educators can work with incarcerated mothers to identify maternal intermediaries, and formal agencies can target interventions to include maternal intermediaries and provide additional assistance to caregivers.

KEYWORDS

caregiving arrangements, gatekeepers, incarcerated mothers, mother–child relationships

Research indicates that most incarcerated women are mothers (60%–80%; Aiello & McQueeney, 2021) who have left behind more than 130,000 minor children in the community (Maruschak et al., 2021). Upon their arrest, many incarcerated women are tasked with securing childcare for their minor children during their incarceration (Enos, 2001). These women are more likely to depend on their own relatives as long-term caregivers (67%), although other caregiving arrangements are sometimes made (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Although much of the current literature has focused on the co-parenting dynamics of caregivers and incarcerated parents, including both incarcerated fathers and mothers (Loper et al., 2014; Miller et al., 2013; Nesmith & Ruhland, 2011; Tasca, 2016), more recent work has begun to consider the differential experiences of incarcerated mothers with children's caregivers (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Baker et al., 2010).

Grandmothers comprise the most common caregiving arrangement for minor children with incarcerated mothers (42% of caregiving arrangements; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010), and thus literature and research findings in this area have largely focused on this caregiving arrangement (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Baker et al., 2010; Pendleton et al., 2022; Strozier et al., 2011). However, more than a third of minor children live with biological fathers during their mother's incarceration (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Given that the quality of mother–caregiver relationships can have significant impacts on mothers' relationships with their children (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Loper et al., 2014) and mothers likely have different relationships with their own mother than with their children's paternal relatives, it is important to begin to parse out the distinctions of these mother–caregiver relationships. To gain a better understanding of these unique caregiver dynamics, this study uses interviews with incarcerated mothers of minor children to explore the women's characterization of their mother–caregiver relationships and the ways these relationships impact mother–child relationships, specifically as the relationships differ between maternal and paternal caregivers.

CAREGIVING ARRANGEMENTS

Before their incarceration, mothers are often the primary caregivers (Barnes & Stringer, 2014; Mackintosh et al., 2006), and sometimes the sole caregivers (Cooper-Sadlo et al., 2019), for minor children. Research suggests that more than half of incarcerated mothers reported living with their minor children in the month before their arrest (55.3%), and 75% of those women were the only caregiver living in the home (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Following a mother's incarceration, caregivers assume the responsibility for children, including caring for children's daily needs, making parenting decisions for children, and facilitating contact between an incarcerated mother and her children (Cecil et al., 2008). Caregiving arrangements may be especially

difficult for families in marginalized communities because families of color experience higher rates of maternal incarceration and are more likely to depend on kinship caregivers, specifically grandparents (Phillips & Bloom, 1998; Ruiz & Kopack, 2014). Caregiving responsibilities come with significant costs, which can strain caregivers financially, especially grandparent caregivers, who are less likely to work, are more likely to experience poor health (Baker et al., 2010), and are often not formally recognized by foster care systems that could provide financial support to children and caregivers (Phillips & Bloom, 1998).

Kinship Caregivers

Kinship caregivers include those who are related to the child in some way—for example, a father, grandparent, aunt, or uncle (Strozier et al., 2011)—whereas nonkinship caregivers are those who are not related to the child, such as a friend or foster care parent. Children most frequently reside with a kinship relative after a mother's incarceration (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010; Moe & Ferraro, 2007; Pendleton et al., 2022; Strozier et al., 2011), generally their nonincarcerated parent (37%) or with another family member (67.7%; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Kinship care is predominantly provided by grandmothers (42%), although incarcerated mothers identify grandfathers (12%) and other relatives (22%) as other kinship caregivers (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Incarcerated mothers report that nonkinship care is provided by a foster home or agency (11%) and by friends/others (8%; “may sum to more than 100% because some prisoners had multiple minor children living with multiple caregivers”; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010, p. 5).

Maternal kinship care generally facilitates better mother–child connections (Hairston, 2007), and maternal grandmothers are often the preferred caregivers (Baker et al., 2010; Barnes & Stringer, 2014). Incarcerated mothers' and maternal grandmothers' lives are intrinsically connected, and thus there is greater effort put into maintaining the relationship between the incarcerated mother and her child, and a greater belief that it is important to do so (Tasca, 2016). Maternal caregivers generally allow incarcerated mothers to be more involved in parenting decisions (Baker et al., 2010; Barnes & Stringer, 2014) and create more opportunities for mothers to be involved with, and informed about, their children (Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021; Young & Smith, 2000). Ultimately, these arrangements during a mother's incarceration can result in better child behavior, reduced childhood trauma, and more successful outcomes for mothers upon their release from prison (Cecil et al., 2008; Strozier et al., 2011).

Alternatively, more than a third of incarcerated mothers report that minor children live with their biological father (37%; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010), although little is known regarding these kinship care arrangements and the implications that mother–paternal caregiver relationships may have on the relationships mothers maintain with their children. Available research suggests that incarcerated mothers may have strained relationships with their children's biological fathers (Arditti & Few, 2006), and biological fathers are much less likely than maternal grandmothers to support mother–child contact through consistent prison visits (Fuller, 1993). Relatedly, Wilson and Koons-Witt (2021) observed that incarcerated mothers planning to reunify with children after their incarceration felt more apprehension about the process when their children were cared for by paternal kinship caregivers instead of maternal relatives.

Gatekeepers

Caregivers act as gatekeepers for the mother–child relationship, playing a critical role in providing or restricting information about, and contact between, an incarcerated parent and their child (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Loper et al., 2014; Tasca, 2016). Caregivers consistently

make decisions regarding what information to share with incarcerated mothers about their children (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021), as well as what information should be shared with children regarding their mother's incarceration (Hairston, 2007; Mignon & Ransford, 2012). Additionally, caregivers often control the amount and type of contact children have with their mother (Baker et al., 2010; Loper et al., 2014), which can ultimately influence the quality of their mother-child relationship (Hairston, 2007; Nesmith & Ruhland, 2011).

Co-Parenting

Co-parenting, which refers to sharing caregiving responsibilities and decision-making for children (Cecil et al., 2008), has frequently been studied in the context of married, divorced, separated, or unmarried parents (Baker et al., 2010; Loper et al., 2014). Although research suggests that these co-parenting relationships have their own unique concerns (Loper et al., 2014), co-parenting alliances that occur between incarcerated mothers and caregivers may include additional challenges that are exacerbated by a mother's incarceration (Baker et al., 2010; Loper et al., 2014; Strozier et al., 2011). Many of these difficulties stem from mothers' physical separation from children and caregivers, wherein contact is heavily regulated by external factors, such as prison policies regarding contact visits and the high expense of making telephone calls (Loper et al., 2014). Moreover, the histories of trauma, mental health issues, and substance abuse that many incarcerated women experience can also contribute to strained co-parenting relationships (Arditti & Few, 2006; Strozier et al., 2011).

Although these relationships may be complicated, co-parenting is essential for maintaining a good mother-child relationship (Baker et al., 2010), and successful co-parenting while the mother is incarcerated may result in reduced behavioral problems (Baker et al., 2010; Loper et al., 2014; Strozier et al., 2011) and better academic outcomes for children (Cecil et al., 2008). Positive co-parenting relationships provide an opportunity to model prosocial interpersonal relationships to children, and strong co-parenting alliances that prioritize children's needs can focus efforts on helping minor children develop socioemotional competencies, including cultivating coping skills and navigating interpersonal peer relationships (Cecil et al., 2008). Additionally strong mother-caregiver relationships can offer stability for children during what can be a traumatic experience of parental incarceration (Cecil et al., 2008).

Being involved in decisions regarding their child is an essential part of parenting from prison for incarcerated mothers (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Cecil et al., 2008; Stringer & Barnes, 2012). Mothers' ability to engage in decision-making regarding their children is usually dictated by the caregiver (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Cecil et al., 2008; Enos, 2001), thus the mother-caregiver relationship has a direct impact on the degree of involvement that incarcerated mothers have in parental decision-making (Barnes & Stringer, 2014; Enos, 2001; Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021). A successful co-parenting alliance allows incarcerated mothers to make decisions regarding their children (Cecil et al., 2008), and the more involvement mothers have, the more optimistic their view of their connection to their children and their caregivers (Loper et al., 2014; Stringer & Barnes, 2012). In other words, allowing mothers to be engaged in decision-making during incarceration results in a better co-parenting alliance (Cecil et al., 2008; Loper et al., 2014).

An essential component of co-parenting for incarcerated mothers is the degree to which mothers are informed about their children (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021). Information sharing can depend on several factors (Loper et al., 2014), including the quality of the mother-caregiver relationship (Young & Smith, 2000) and the physical proximity of mothers to their families (Strozier et al., 2011). Incarcerated mothers' physical absence from the home (Strozier et al., 2011), coupled with strained mother-caregiver relationships, can result in reduced information sharing, making co-parenting more difficult (Loper et al., 2014; Young & Smith, 2000).

Contact

Caregivers often act as gatekeepers by facilitating or restricting contact between an incarcerated mother and her children (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Nesmith & Ruhland, 2011; Poehlmann-Tynan, 2020; Tasca, 2016). There are a variety of ways that children and caregivers can have contact with an incarcerated parent, including writing letters or emails, making phone calls, and visiting incarcerated mothers at detention facilities. Nonphysical forms of contact, such as letter-writing and phone calls, are used more regularly than physical visits (Christian, 2005; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010; Hairston, 2007), and almost half of state prison systems provide access to videoconferencing (Dallaire et al., 2021). In their research of contact between incarcerated mothers and their children, Mignon and Ransford (2012) found that most mother-child contact occurred through mail (78%) or phone calls (60%), whereas less than half of the mothers reported having face-to-face visits with their children (45%).

Although emails, letter mail, and phone calls are generally more accessible forms of contact and thus are more frequently used (Christian, 2005; Mignon & Ransford, 2012), women and children still experience barriers with these methods of communication. Sending mail can place a burden on indigent incarcerated women (Moe & Ferraro, 2007; Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021), and many penitentiaries do not provide access to email (Johnson, 2016), even though this would be a more cost-effective form of communication for incarcerated women. Additionally, literacy challenges may hinder the accessibility of both letter and email writing (Moe & Ferraro, 2007; Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021). Although telephone calls might alleviate some of these obstacles, they are often prohibitively expensive for the families of incarcerated parents (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Hairston, 2007; Poehlmann et al., 2010), further limiting not just mother-child contact but also information sharing between caregivers and mothers (Young & Smith, 2000).

Contact visits tend to be the least commonly reported form of mother-child contact (Hairston, 2007; Mignon & Ransford, 2012), likely due to a variety of obstacles. Incarcerated mothers are often housed hundreds of miles away from their children (Arditti & Few, 2006; Hairston, 2007), which can result in high costs of transportation to travel to the penitentiary (Barnes & Stringer, 2014; Poehlmann et al., 2010) and difficulty coordinating long trips with caregivers' schedules (Young & Smith, 2000; for an expanded discussion regarding barriers to prison visits, see Christian, 2005). Additionally, prisons themselves can institute barriers to contact visits (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Nesmith & Ruhland, 2011), such as limited visiting schedules, crowded visiting spaces, and regulations regarding the physical contact mothers may have with children (Poehlmann et al., 2010; Young & Smith, 2000). Although contact visits are important for the maintenance of the mother-child relationship (Tasca, 2016), physical visits are fraught with difficulties that limit contact between incarcerated mothers and their families.

CURRENT STUDY

Because caregivers often serve as gatekeepers between incarcerated mothers and their children, essentially regulating information, access, and decision-making power, the mother-caregiver relationship largely enables or prohibits mothers' ability to co-parent from prison (Cecil et al., 2008; Poehlmann-Tynan, 2020; Tasca, 2016). However, limited research has focused extensively on mother-caregiver relationships for incarcerated mothers specifically. Research regarding incarcerated parents and caregivers has often considered parental incarceration generally (Loper et al., 2014; Miller et al., 2013; Nesmith & Ruhland, 2011), although research suggests there are stark differences between incarcerated mothers and fathers. Incarcerated fathers most frequently interact with children's biological mothers as caregivers, whereas incarcerated mothers often rely on their own parents to care for their minor children (Cecil et al., 2008; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010).

Research that has focused more narrowly on co-caregiving alliances and the experiences of incarcerated mothers has frequently focused on mother–grandmother dynamics (Aeillo & McQueeney, 2021; Baker et al., 2010; Strozier et al., 2011) because most minor children of incarcerated mothers live with maternal grandmothers during their mother’s incarceration (Mignon & Ransford, 2012; Strozier et al., 2011; Tasca, 2016). Notably, little research has explored mother–caregiver relationships when biological fathers or other paternal relatives care for young children, although more than a third of minor children live with paternal caregivers in their mother’s absence (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Using in-depth interviews of 14 incarcerated mothers of 29 minor children with varying types of caregiving arrangements, the current study uses an inductive approach aimed at filling this gap in the literature by exploring (a) how incarcerated mothers characterize their mother–caregiver relationships and (b) how these relationships impact the connections they have with their children, focusing specifically on the ways these experiences differ between maternal and paternal caregivers.

METHODS

This study uses data from a larger project examining motherhood and criminal desistance, including how mothers prepare for and anticipate reuniting with their children. The study took place at one corrections facility for women located in the southeastern region of the United States. During the original study, the state corrections system incarcerated approximately 1,400 women (6.7%) out of a total of 21,000 inmates. The state corrections department managed several facilities for women at varying custody levels. Participants were purposively sampled from a prison facility that housed approximately 500 women and provided researchers with a pool of women who were more diverse in terms of custody levels, special populations, and available programs. The study received institutional review board (IRB) approval from the university and formal approval for data collection from the state department of corrections.

Sample selection

Women at the facility were eligible to participate in the study if they were 18 years or older, had at least one child, had served a minimum of 12 months of their sentence, and were within 6 months of being released from the facility. The eligibility criteria ensured researchers were able to focus on women’s incarceration experiences and their mother–child relationships, as well as their plans for community reentry and reunification. Using intake and visitation records, the department of corrections identified a pool of prospective women from which to draw a sample (target of 40 women). As part of the study IRB requirements, any prospective participant who was cognitively impaired or who had extreme (violent) behavior issues as identified by the corrections system was ineligible to participate in the study. Moreover, a prospective participant could be removed from the pool and the study before their participation if research staff determined that the subject was unable to consent or respond to questions. All mothers with a minor-age child were prioritized and selected first because a substantial portion of the interview involved experiences with separation, contact with children, caregivers, and reunification plans. Ultimately, 53 eligible participants were identified.

Sampled women received an invitation letter briefly explaining the study along with a scheduled time for them to meet with a member of the research staff. A corrections officer escorted the prospective study participant to a private room on the grounds of the facility where the participant met with an interviewer to learn more about the study and complete informed consent procedures. The corrections officer did not remain in the private meeting room during informed consent or during any subsequent interviews. A total of 14 (or 26%) prospective participants

were either released to the community, moved to another state facility, placed in secured housing (lock-up), or reported that they had no children (two women) and therefore were not interviewed for the study. For the remaining eligible women, 22 of 39 incarcerated mothers agreed to participate in the study (56%). The response rate was likely impacted by the sensitive topic about their children. For instance, many incarcerated women feel guilt and shame about their circumstance and find it too painful to talk about their children, whereas others may be concerned about their parental rights and discussing the whereabouts and caregiving situation of minor children. This article focuses on the experiences of incarcerated mothers with the caregivers of their minor age children, thus the sample used for the current study includes only those women with at least one minor child ($n = 14$ mothers). Women with adult-only children who were removed from the study differed from the remaining women in that they were more likely to be divorced or separated than women with minor children and included a less racially heterogeneous group than mothers with minor children.

Data collection

The semistructured interview form contained 25 questions and probes in three main areas: background and pre-prison experiences (e.g., marital or relationship status, living situation, detailed information on children), women's experiences while incarcerated (e.g., involvement in programming, coping with separation, contact with children and other family members), post-prison planning or preparation (e.g., transitional programming, plans for employment), and their plans about returning home (e.g., intentions to reunify, resume caregiving role, concerns for reentry). Eligible women were interviewed between April and June 2015. Informed consent and the interview took approximately 90 minutes to complete. The state department of corrections did not permit the use of tape recorders; therefore, interview staff were required to write down responses on the interview document. Jottings and short-hand notes were used during the interview, and at the end of the interview, the research staff returned to the office to convert the jottings and notes into more detailed data that was formatted into a word document. Each interview was then imported into NVIVO for data management, coding, and analysis.

Data analysis

An inductive approach to the data analysis was used for the current work. The inductive approach allowed researchers to review the data holistically to identify what themes were present in the data (as opposed to a deductive approach wherein a theoretical framework is used to guide the project and subsequent data analysis; Kiger & Varpio, 2020). Two members of the research staff read interview transcripts and coded portions of the interview where participants discussed information on their children, caregivers, and their motherhood roles. Several questions in the semistructured interview asked specifically about caregivers. For example, the background section identified the current caregiver(s) for each minor-age child(ren) and characterized the caregiver's relationship to the mother. Additional questions asked participants to describe their mother-caregiver relationships. This question also included follow-up probes about how any disagreements were resolved and in what ways (if any) mothers were included in decisions concerning their children. The analysis included data from these questions, but it also included instances in which caregivers were discussed by mothers in relation to other interview questions not directly focused on caregivers. This sometimes occurred in mothers' responses to questions about the contact they have with their children or around questions concerning programming and reentry planning.

As researchers read across the interview instruments, they began to identify codes within the data that were related to incarcerated mothers' discussions of their children's caregivers (Harding, 2018). Saldaña (2016) explained that "a code is a researcher-generated construct that symbolizes or translates data" (p. 4). After several iterations of coding (Saldaña, 2016), primary codes around mothers' relationships with caregivers and their connections with their children were identified. Once the interviews were coded, themes from these codes were identified. For example, the "Contact with children" code noted how caregivers facilitated (or blocked) contact between them and their children (subcodes included the following: consistent, inconsistent, none, blocked contact), and the theme around mother-child contact was identified.

To understand commonalities and differences that mothers experienced based on the relationship they had with their children's caregivers, researchers engaged in both thematic and comparative analyses (Glesne, 2016; Harding, 2018). Asserting that one project can include both forms of analyses, Harding (2018) described thematic analysis as an approach in which dominant patterns and overarching themes are identified and comparative analysis as focusing on the differences and similarities of participants' lived experiences. To engage in both thematic and comparative analyses, mother-caregiver dyads were separated in a table between maternal and paternal caregivers for each theme (Glesne, 2016; Harding, 2018). This visualization tool allowed for a clearer comparison of maternal and paternal caregivers and further revealed more distinct differences in mothers' experiences based on their children's caregiving arrangement. For example, when using a table to organize data around caregivers' facilitation (or lack thereof) of mother-child relationships, it became clear that although several mothers whose children resided with paternal caregivers discussed maintaining consistent contact with their children, much of this contact was facilitated not by the paternal caregiver but instead by maternal relatives.

FINDINGS

Sample characteristics

The mothers in this study ($n = 14$) were on average 37 years old (range: 26–53 years), were predominantly White (57%; Black, 36%) and single (64%; divorced, 21%; married, 7%). They were serving average sentences of approximately 7 years (range: 2.5–20 years) for property (43%), violent (29%), drug (14%), and other types (14%) of offenses. Study participants typically had their first child at 21 years of age (range: 15–32 years), had on average three children (range: 1–5 children), and, at the time of the interviews, most of the participants (71%) only had minor-age children. Additionally, most women (57%) were the primary caregivers of their children and lived with them before their incarceration, while one woman lived with her children but did not provide care. The remaining women did not reside with their children before their imprisonment (29%) or were pregnant with their first child (14%) at the time of their arrest.

Mother-caregiver dyads

Data analysis first involved identifying the caregiver(s) for each child and noting the caregiver(s)'s relationship to the child or mother. The 14 mothers in the study had a total of 29 minor-age children among them. Each mother-caregiver dyad was identified as being either maternal, paternal, or other (see Table 1). A maternal mother-caregiver dyad is one where the caregiver for the minor-age child is a maternal relative (e.g., participant's mother, participant's sister, etc.), whereas a paternal mother-caregiver dyad involves a caregiver of the minor child being a paternal relative to the child (e.g., child's father, child's paternal grandparent). The

TABLE 1 Mother by minor child and caregiver arrangement ($n = 14$ Mothers)

Mother ^a	Minor-age children	Type of caregiver dyad	Total caregiver dyads	Unique caregiver dyads
Ashley	1	Child 1: participant's mother and stepfather (<i>m</i>)	1	1
Nicole	2	Child 1: participant's grandmother ^b (<i>m</i>) Child 2: participant's great aunt ^b (<i>m</i>)	2	2
Mary	2	Child 1: brother and wife of former boyfriend (<i>o</i>) Child 2: brother and wife of former boyfriend (<i>o</i>)	2	1
Kelly	2	Child 1: child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 2: foster care (<i>o</i>)	2	2
Beth	2	Child 1: participant's parents (<i>m</i>) Child 2: participant's parents (<i>m</i>)	2	1
Megan	4	Child 1: aunt of the child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 2: aunt of the child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 3: foster care (<i>o</i>) Child 4: foster care (<i>o</i>)	4	2
Crystal	2	Child 1: participant's parents (<i>m</i>) Child 2: participant's parents (<i>m</i>)	2	1
Lori	1	Child 1: foster care (<i>o</i>)	1	1
Julie	1	Child 1: participant's mother (<i>m</i>)	1	1
Brenda	1	Child 1: participant's mother (<i>m</i>)	1	1
Lauren	3	Child 1: great aunt of child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 2: great aunt of child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 3: child's father (<i>p</i>)	3	2
Danielle	3	Child 1: child's father (<i>p</i>) Child 2: child's paternal grandfather (<i>p</i>) Child 3: child's paternal grandfather (<i>p</i>)	3	2
Erica	2	Child 1: participant's sister (<i>m</i>) Child 2: participant's sister (<i>m</i>)	2	1
Rachel	3	Child 1: participant's sister (<i>m</i>) Child 2: participant's sister (<i>m</i>) Child 3: child's father (<i>p</i>)	3	2
Totals	29 minor children	13 total mother–maternal caregiver dyads 10 total mother–paternal caregiver dyads 6 total mother–caregiver other dyads	29 total dyads	20 unique dyads

Note: *m* = maternal caregivers; *o* = other caregivers; *p* = paternal caregivers.

^aPseudonyms were used to protect participants' privacy; pseudonyms differ from other publications using the same sample of women out of concern for possible identification.

^bBoth maternal relatives were living together while providing care for the two children.

“other” mother–caregiver dyad is noted when the caregiver of the minor age child is someone other than a maternal or paternal relative (e.g., foster parent, friend; the “other” mother–caregiver dyad group is excluded from the current analysis because it is outside the scope of the article).

Given that there are a total of 29 minor-age children, there are also a total of 29 possible mother–caregiver dyads. Importantly, when mothers have multiple children, there is a possibility that their children could be cared for by different caregivers—thus, 20 *unique* dyads were identified in the sample. In the cases where multiple children were with the same caregiver, that would represent one unique mother–caregiver dyad. Almost half of the unique mother–caregiver dyads were maternal (45%), followed by paternal (34%), and the remaining unique

mother–caregiver dyads were identified as “other” (21%). This finding suggests that some of the mothers in the study were coordinating with multiple caregivers for their children, which can result in complicated situations and experiences should mothers desire to have connections with their children during their imprisonment. Notably, the mother–caregiver dyads explored in this study comprise the caregiving relationships participants described, not necessarily the formal arrangements recognized by the state. For example, Nicole shared that her grandmother has parental rights for both of her children, although her great aunt informally assists in caring for one child. This approach of identifying mother–caregiver dyads is reflective of the mothers’ lived experiences, but it is also necessary when considering the complicated situations the mothers described.

Mother–caregiver relationships

The first research objective focuses on the ways that the mothers in the sample view their mother–caregiver relationships, exploring specifically potential differences of mothers’ characterizations of their relationships between maternal and paternal caregivers. Mothers with maternal caregivers generally expressed having a positive relationship with their children’s caregivers and shared that they often turn to these caregivers when they have concerns and anxieties related to their children. Mothers with paternal caregivers seemed split in their perception of their mother–caregiver relationships, with about half of the mothers describing that relationship as positive and the other half of the mothers advising that they do not have any relationship or contact with their children’s caregiver(s). Mothers with paternal caregivers equated receiving regular information about their children as being a positive mother–caregiver relationship, whereas mothers with maternal caregivers often described much more complex mother–caregiver relationships that were intrinsically important to them even beyond the caregiving arrangement.

Maternal caregiver relationships

Good, but complicated relationship

Most of the mothers with maternal caregivers characterized their mother–caregiver relationships as “good” or “wonderful.” These mothers generally discussed feeling supported by their children’s caregivers, advising that their relatives provided a range of support, including financial resources and emotional support. Several of these mothers reported speaking directly to their children’s caregivers when they experienced maternal stress or had concerns about their children. Ashley noted, “I call home when I get upset,” and Erica indicated that she talks with her older sister “about the kids and she is very supportive.”

Although generally recognized as positive, the mothers also described these relationships with careful nuance, describing them as “strained” or otherwise complicated. These intricacies were often attributed to the women’s history of criminal behavior, wherein they felt that their maternal relatives were hurt or disappointed in their pre-prison lifestyle.

I have a good relationship with my mom. We have good conversations. Before I had [my baby], we butted heads. My life wasn’t right. She told me that she waited 15 years for me to act right. (Ashley)

I have a beautiful relationship with my grandmother. She is a strong woman and is 100% supportive in getting me on my feet and doing better. Before prison she was hurt with me. I was using drugs like my own parents. I was messing up, too. (Nicole, Child 1)

Relatedly, the only mother who reported having no relationship with her children's maternal caregiver, Rachel, explained that this was primarily because "I don't know much about [my sister]. I was the black sheep of the family." Like the other mothers, Rachel identifies her own criminal activity as harming her relationships with maternal relatives.

Valued relationship

Mother-caregiver relationships seemed especially important to the mothers, and for some women, their incarceration served as a time for them to repair the relationships with their relatives. In describing her struggles with depression upon her incarceration, Beth explained, "My mom wouldn't talk to me. I got no letters. I didn't talk to her. I don't blame her, but it was hard." Beth went on to share that it was important to her that her mother forgave her for the ways that she had harmed her family prior to her arrest, attributing that process to a religious-based program at the prison facility that supports a family day as part of its curriculum. Following the program, Beth stated that her conversations with her parents had "been good" as they were able to "discuss happy things, not the past."

Paternal caregiver relationships

"Good" or no relationship

In contrast to the simultaneously positive and complicated relationships that mothers with maternal caregivers described, mothers whose children were residing with paternal caregivers frequently viewed these relationships as either "good" or nonexistent, although two mothers seemed to oscillate in their characterization of their mother-caregiver relationship as nonexistent or sometimes negative. These two mothers, whose children were cared for by their biological fathers, described strained relationships with caregivers that seemed heavily influenced by their former romantic partnerships. Kelly initially explained that she had no relationship with her child's caregiver, but then stated that "when I do communicate with him, it is not civil." Rachel described a similar dynamic, wherein she did not speak to her child's caregiver for 4 years, explaining that he "plays games."

One mother, Megan, described a very strong positive relationship with her children's paternal caregiver because they "love her" and she receives "great support from [the paternal] family," but her experience was unique. Lauren and Danielle discussed what seemed to be the more common experience for mothers in the sample whose children were being cared for by paternal caregivers. They both characterized their relationships as positive, but they seemed to treat the presence of *any* relationship with a paternal caregiver as good. For example, although she described only minimal interaction with her children's caregiver, Danielle ultimately felt she had a "good relationship" with her children's paternal grandfather (Child 2 and 3). She recalled:

I call the caregiver of my youngest two children sometimes maybe for 3 to 5 minutes on the phone. I talked to him four times a month (every Saturday) for the first couple of years ... but now it is about once a month. It is a good relationship, but he doesn't really share too much with me. He just tells me that they are okay.

Danielle's depiction of this relationship as "good" is notable in its contrast to her other children's paternal caregiver, in which she had no contact at all with the caregiver or her child. Lauren described a similar experience where, although she had limited contact with the biological father of one of her children, she described having no contact at all with the paternal caregiver of her other two children. Lauren and Danielle's experiences reveal that for some

mothers, having any form of access to their children's paternal caregivers is viewed as positive, especially when they may have no contact at all with their other children's caregivers.

Marginal relationship

Another observed difference between maternal and paternal caregiver relationships is that while mothers with maternal caregivers often treated these relationships as equally important to their mother-child relationships, mothers with paternal caregivers seemed generally less invested in their mother-caregiver relationships. Even mothers with paternal caregivers who later shared the ways that caregivers worked to limit their mother-child relationships did not seem preoccupied with these relationships, viewing their mother-caregiver relationships as existing solely to provide care for their children. For example, both Rachel and Kelly shared that their children's paternal caregivers had worked to negatively impact their mother-child relationship, however, neither Rachel nor Kelly focused extensively on these mother-caregiver relationships. Instead, these mothers treated their mother-caregiver relationships largely as peripheral and focused primarily on the importance of their mother-child relationships.

Mother-child relationships

The second research objective explores the ways that mother-caregiver arrangements influence the connections that incarcerated mothers have with their children and how they may vary by caregiver arrangement. Mothers' experiences generally differed between maternal and paternal caregivers. Mothers whose children lived with maternal caregivers described the ways that their children's caregivers supported their mother-child relationships, involved them in parenting decisions, and facilitated contact. In contrast, several mothers with paternal caregivers described experiences when their children's caregivers limited access to and information about their children. Notably, several mothers in these circumstances shared ways that their own relatives had worked on their behalf to maintain their mother-child relationship.

Maternal caregivers and mother-child relationships

Caregivers facilitate mother-child contact

Some mothers recognized the important role that caregivers play in establishing and maintaining their mother-child relationships, largely attributing their ability to maintain a relationship with their children to the purposeful efforts of their children's caregivers. Ashley, who gave birth while incarcerated, described her mother's careful planning of contact visits, specifically bringing the baby to the prison on dates that were generally less crowded and ultimately less distracting and overwhelming for Ashley and her baby. Crystal, whose child was very young when she went to prison, also credited her mother with facilitating continued bonding and a relationship with her child. As Crystal described it, "My mother has done a good job in helping [my child and I] to get to know each other and having contact with one another. She supports our relationship."

For incarcerated mothers, caregivers who support their mother-child relationships are preferable, for this support is crucial in enabling mothers to bond and communicate with their children. Unsurprisingly, the mothers' ability to (re)build their mother-child relationships seemed related to their access to their children. Nicole explained that her relationship with her son "got better with each visit," and Crystal attributed her improving relationship with her daughter to email contact wherein her daughter "can express herself."

As evidenced by both these mothers, contact between them and their children can have important implications on bonding during their separation. Mother-child contact generally depends on caregivers, who decide the types and frequency of contact. The differences between

mothers whose children live with maternal caregivers and those with paternal caregivers were stark for the women in the sample (Table 2). All mothers whose children lived with maternal caregivers reported regular or consistent contact with their children, usually citing a variety of contact methods as well.

I call my mom’s every Saturday. I talk to my kids about once a month. I write them about once a month. Mom will send cards, like a Christian card or an affirmation. She just signs them, “Love, Mom.” (Beth)

I have had frequent visits, phone calls, and mail and email communication. In the beginning, I used to get a visit with them once a month, but later on it changed to about three or four times a year because lives became more busy and complicated with taking care of those with illnesses. I used to talk by phone every day in the beginning ... we have slowed down the phone calls so it won’t cost as much money for my parents, and they can save money. (Crystal)

Caregiver supports co-parenting

Caregivers can also choose how regularly mothers are informed about their children and how much information they share about minor children’s daily lives. All but one of the mothers whose children lived with maternal caregivers reported that they were either directly involved in decision-making regarding their children or were regularly informed about their children’s well-being. These mothers generally felt included in, or at the very least informed about, the parenting

TABLE 2 Mother–child contact by unique caregiver dyads (maternal vs. paternal)

Mother	Type of contact with child			Frequency of contact	
	Mail/ email	Phone	Face-to-face	Regular	Not regular
<i>Maternal unique caregiver dyads</i>					
Ashley			X	X	
Nicole, Child 1	X		X	X	
Nicole, Child 2	X		X	X	
Beth ^a		X		X	
Crystal	X	X	X	X	
Julie	X	X	X	X	
Brenda	X	X	X	X	
Erica	X	X		X	
Rachel, Child 1 and 2	X	X	X	X	
<i>Paternal unique caregiver dyads</i>					
Kelly, Child 1 ^b		X	X		X
Megan, Child 1 and 2 ^c	X	X			X
Lauren, Child 1					
Lauren, Child 2 and 3					
Danielle, Child 1					
Danielle, Child 2 and 3					
Rachel, Child 3					

^aCaregiver has physical disability that limits ability to bring kids for face-to-face visitation.
^bParticipant’s sister facilitates visits and phone calls (not the paternal caregiver).
^cParticipant refuses face-to-face visits.

process. Rachel recalled being asked about sending her child to summer camp and her thoughts on obtaining a tutor for her son who was struggling in school. Erica felt included in the parenting process even for smaller things that she referred to as “trivial.” Erica acknowledged that “this is stuff [the caregiver] can decide, but she makes it a point of asking me [for my thoughts].”

Although they were kept informed about their children, some mothers still struggled with not being present or included in the daily decision-making for their children.

In the beginning I struggled with that with my [kids’ caregivers]. She would say that I need to allow her to do what she needed to do to care for them. [My] father stepped in and explained that [they] were doing the best that they could do for the kids and that [I] needed to let her care for them ... [the kids] were doing well and [my parents] could take care of them. ... I’ve learned that in here I can’t control out there. I cannot parent them from behind bars and keep my sanity. I try to remember and look at the positive and not worry. I now let go and it is easier for me. (Crystal)

They don’t really include me. My mom is so tired and sick [because of medical issues]. She just makes sure they get good grades, have clothes, and are taken care of. (Beth)

While being informed about their children and included in decision-making seemed important to many of the mothers, Crystal and Beth’s experiences highlight the difficulties that caregivers and incarcerated mothers face when trying to manage and coordinate children’s care. Mothers may want to be included in these daily decisions, but it can be difficult for caregivers to include mothers regularly, especially when they are experiencing additional struggles related to caring for themselves and minor children. Overall, women whose children live with maternal caregivers were regularly informed about their children and included in parenting decisions, suggesting that these caregiving arrangements enabled incarcerated mothers to be more involved than alternative arrangements.

Paternal caregivers and mother–child relationships

Caregiver restricts co-parenting

Mothers whose children reside with paternal caregivers were normally less included in parental decision-making than mothers whose children live with maternal relatives. Apart from two mothers, participants whose children lived with paternal caregivers shared that they were either not included in decisions regarding their children or they were not regularly informed about their care. Moreover, several mothers whose children lived with paternal caregivers explained that their children’s caregivers had actively worked to compromise the relationships they had with their children.

[My kids’ caregiver] thinks that I will come back when I get out. ... He says he is a good dad, but I have no clue. I’ve tried to bring [social services] in. [The caseworker] was going to try to bring [my daughter] here to visit, but [the caregiver] changed his mind. (Rachel, Child 3)

My daughter is court-ordered to visit [me] every other weekend but her father does not bring her. ... [I] went without seeing or talking with my daughter for the first 8 months of my sentence. Her father kept her away from [me]. Her father would open the mail and not give it to her. (Kelly, Child 1)

In describing how her daughter’s caregiver had purposefully limited contact between her and her daughter, Kelly explained that he had “tried to turn her against me but our bond is so

strong.” For these mothers, paternal caregivers actively worked to restrict co-parenting through limited maternal involvement and information sharing.

Caregiver limits mother–child contact

In contrast to mothers with maternal caregiving arrangements, mothers whose children lived with paternal caregivers reported much less contact, both in the type of contact and in the frequency of contact (Table 2).

I always write the two youngest [kids], but they don’t answer. I write them about twice a month. I don’t have an address for my oldest daughter, so I don’t write her ... [We have] no contact through phone calls ... although [I] sometimes call the caregiver to check on [my] youngest two girls, [there are] no face-to-face visits. (Danielle, Child 1, 2, and 3)

I’ve received one letter. My daughter wrote to me last May. I write to [my kids] when I can, once a month. [My children’s caregiver] doesn’t want them to talk to me. (Lauren, Child 1 and 2)

These findings highlight some of the differential experiences between mothers whose children lived with maternal and paternal caregivers. While mothers with maternal caregivers undoubtedly experienced some difficulties with caregivers, only mothers with paternal caregivers discussed caregivers who actively worked to split up the mothers and their children.

Maternal relatives as intermediaries in mother–child relationships

When their children’s paternal caregivers failed to support their mother–child relationship or actively worked to separate the children from their mother, both Kelly and Danielle depended on their own relatives to support their mother–child relationships and provide them with information about their children. Although the child’s paternal caregiver refused to provide contact between Kelly and her daughter, Kelly’s sister brought her daughter to the facility for contact visits. Moreover, when she wanted to speak with her daughter on the phone, Kelly called her sister, who then dialed in her daughter through a three-way phone call. While Danielle explained that her children’s caregiver did not intentionally limit contact, he did not purposefully include her in decisions or regularly speak with her regarding her children. Instead, Danielle depended on her brother to learn about what was going on in her children’s lives.

I talk to my older brother and my older sister [when I am upset or concerned about my children]. My older brother lives nearby my two youngest kids and he tells me how the [kids] are doing. He has contact with the children. (Danielle, Child 2 and 3)

These mothers were dependent on their maternal relatives to facilitate access to and information about their children, which highlights some of the difficulties that women face when their children are cared for by paternal caregivers. These findings also emphasize the important role that mothers’ relatives can play in supporting their mother–child relationships and providing emotional support to incarcerated mothers, even if they do not serve as children’s primary caregivers. (Table 3 presents the five main themes of caregiver arrangement, mother–caregiver relationship, mother–child contact, co-parenting, and mother–child relationship, along with associated codes and text illustrations.)

TABLE 3 Central themes, codes, and text illustrations

Theme	Definition	Codes	Illustration
Caregiver arrangement	Caregiver for a child of an incarcerated mother	Maternal; paternal; other ^a	Maternal: subject's mother Paternal: child's father Other: foster care
Mother-caregiver relationship	The status or type of relationship a mother has with the caregiver(s) of her children	Good; strained; improving; none; negative	Good: "My relationship with my mother is wonderful." (Julie) None: "I have no contact with [the caregiver]." (Danielle)
Mother-child contact	Interactions between a mother and her child(ren) by phone, mail, or in person	Consistent; in-consistent; none; blocked contact	Consistent: "I look forward to the visits. They come every Sunday from 1 p.m. to 5 p.m." (Nicole) Inconsistent/blocked: "I write to [my kids] when I can, once a month. [Their caregiver] doesn't want them to talk to me." (Lauren)
Co-parenting	Sharing in the decisions made about her child(ren) or being familiar with how they are doing	Included in decisions; informed about children; not included or informed	Included in decisions: "I'm always asked before she does anything. When he wanted to let his hair grow out, she said he had to ask me first." (Julie) Informed about children: "I've learned that in here I can't control out there. I cannot parent them from behind bars and keep my sanity." (Crystal)
Mother-child relationship	The status or type of relationship a mother has with her child(ren)	Rebuilt in prison; good; strained; consistent; no relationship; rebuild after prison	Strained: "I call every Saturday. I'm lucky if either one will speak to me for a few minutes. They are polite and respectful. I've been gone for so long." (Beth) Rebuild after prison: "I don't have a relationship with [my children], but I would like a relationship with them when I get out of prison." (Danielle)

^aOther caregiving arrangements are not included in the data analysis of the current work.

Thematic maps for maternal and paternal caregiving arrangements

The current findings suggest that the caregiving arrangements for incarcerated mothers have considerable consequences for their mothering experiences during their detention in prison. Figure 1 illustrates the thematic map for maternal caregiving arrangements. The maternal caregiving arrangement often coincides with a positive relationship between the mother and the caregiver, or at the minimum a relationship that is viewed by the mother as important and worthy of improving. Because the caregiver maintains significant control and decision-making within this dynamic, they often determine the co-parenting role the mother can assume during her imprisonment. Co-parenting might involve mothers being consulted on decisions or merely

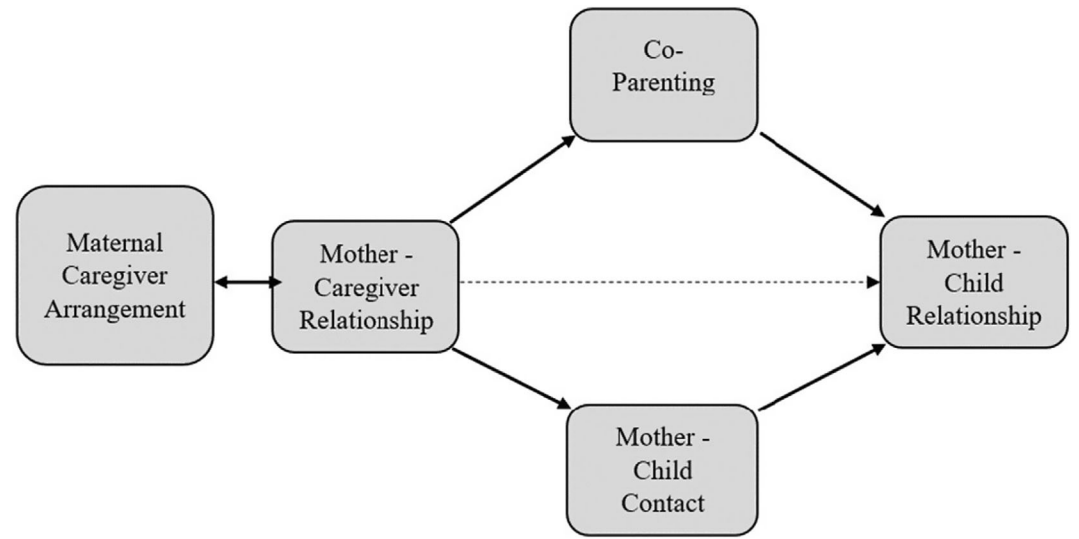


FIGURE 1 Thematic map for maternal caregiving arrangements

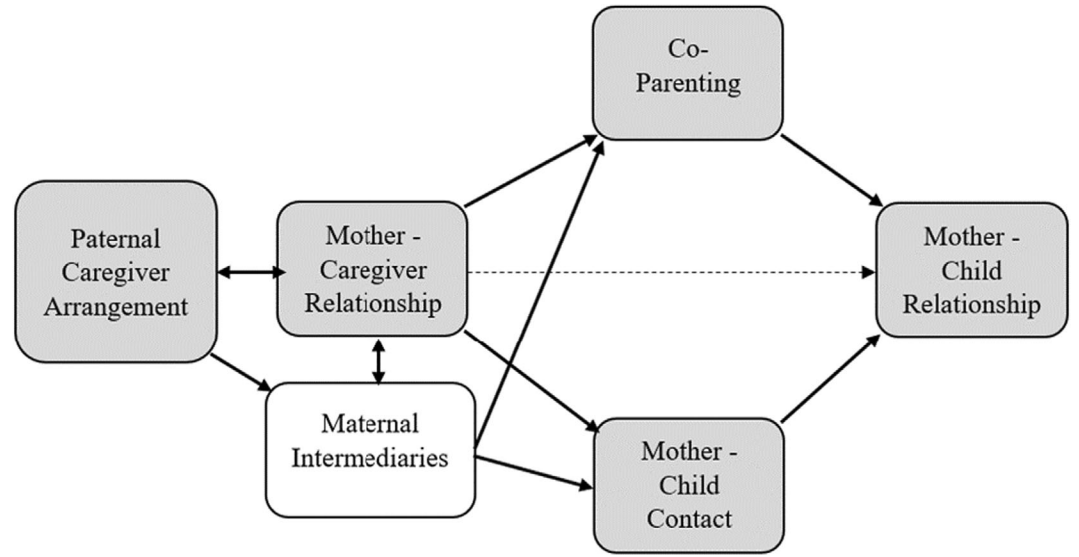


FIGURE 2 Thematic map for paternal caregiving arrangements

being informed about events or milestones in the child’s life. Thus, the nature of the relationship between mothers and caregivers of their children is important because it can lead to opportunities for a successful co-parenting alliance. Mothers with maternal caregivers were generally provided co-parenting opportunities.

Caregivers can also influence the type and amount of contact between mothers and their children. An important distinction between maternal and paternal caregiving arrangements involved contact between mothers and their children. Children who were placed in maternal caregiving arrangements had much more contact with their mothers during her imprisonment. Their ability to interact with their children during their incarceration ultimately allowed women

and their children to maintain or rebuild their relationship during their separation. While it is likely that the mother–caregiver relationship itself can directly impact the mother–child relationship (e.g., how caregivers talk to children about their mothers; see McCormick et al., 2014), those dynamics were not examined in the current study but are tentatively included in the thematic maps as a connection that is important to consider in future research.

The thematic map for the paternal caregiving arrangement is presented in Figure 2. It portrays the connection between key themes such as mother–caregiver relationships, co-parenting, contact, and mother–child relationships in the same manner but highlights the addition of maternal intermediaries for some of the mother–paternal caregiving dyads. In these instances, maternal family members served as liaisons between paternal caregivers and incarcerated mothers by stepping in to facilitate co-parenting (i.e., keeping them informed about their children) and contact between mothers and their children. This adaptation minimized any necessary interaction between incarcerated mothers and paternal caregivers who were often uninvested in a co-parenting alliance with mothers and frequently acted as staunch gatekeepers.

DISCUSSION

This study contributes to the current literature regarding incarcerated mothers and caregivers, specifically by exploring the differential experiences of incarcerated mothers whose children live with maternal and paternal caregivers. One of the important findings from this study is that mothers whose children live with maternal caregivers often emphasized the importance of *both* their mother–caregiver and mother–child relationships. These women generally had positive but, in some cases, complicated connections with caregivers, wherein they worked to repair strained relationships that predated their confinement in prison. Notably, these reparative efforts often occurred during the women’s incarceration. For many families, the mother’s incarceration may be only one of a string of dysfunction and problematic behaviors or lifestyle choices (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Strozier et al., 2011), and these previous interactions may contribute to tension in the mother–caregiver relationship (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021). However, the fact that mothers were heavily invested in the relationships they have with their maternal relatives has important repercussions during and after mothers’ incarceration. For instance, a more positive relationship between incarcerated mothers and their own relatives who are caring for their children could lead to an easier transition during reentry (Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021) and more optimism from mothers regarding that process (Stringer & Barnes, 2012).

Another key finding from this study focuses on mother–child relationships. About a third of the mothers in the study discussed rebuilding relationships with their children, but women were split on *when* they were able to repair these relationships. Notably, this distinction seemed connected to the childcare arrangement, with women whose children lived with maternal caregivers discussing their ability to begin repairing these relationships in the short term, whereas several of the women whose children lived with paternal caregivers explained that they were waiting until after their release from prison to reconnect with their children. These mothers often viewed their motherhood role and mother–child relationship as “suspended” (Easterling et al., 2019), and they were merely waiting until they reentered the community to reestablish a relationship with their children and assume that role once again.

Finally, a significant contribution of the current study is the emergence of the important intermediary role that maternal relatives serve within the complex relationships that mothers have with paternal caregivers and their children. The current findings indicate that strong co-parenting alliances are most closely realized in maternal caregiving arrangements and are much less present within paternal caregiving arrangements. However, several women in the study described adapting to these situations through the introduction of maternal intermediaries who provided co-parenting opportunities through information sharing and facilitated mother–child

contact. Co-parenting theory emphasizes the importance of power-sharing within family units, suggesting that a collaborative partnership between both adults signals to children that there is unity, support, and stability, creating a more secure family environment (Cecil et al., 2008). When paternal caregivers limit mothers' access to children during their incarceration, the imbalance of power between caregivers in the community and mothers in prison solidifies caregivers' gatekeeping role. Although the current study did not examine the effects of these arrangements on child outcomes or speak with the children directly, Cecil et al. (2008) warned that with imbalanced and hostile co-parenting situations, "children suffer yet another form of worry, confusion, and uncertainty entrapped by loyalty conflicts and choosing sides" (p. 516). The fact that mothers adapt to paternal caregivers' gatekeeping efforts by seeking out a maternal intermediary highlights the ways that mothers strive to continue their parenting role during separation and emphasizes the importance they place on co-parenting opportunities. The current study was guided by an inductive approach, and findings have implications for co-parenting theory, family sciences, and corrections research. Drawing on comparisons between maternal and paternal caregiving arrangements, the findings inform an understanding of how those family structures and decisions can impact experiences around co-parenting alliances, contact, and ultimately the relationships between mothers and their children.

Implications for prison policy

Mothers whose children lived with paternal caregivers were rarely included in decisions concerning their children and often described minimal information sharing, thus leading to a negligible or nonexistent co-parenting alliance. In response, mothers sometimes recruited their own relatives to act as an intermediary between them, the caregivers, and their children, highlighting several important policy implications for prisons. Prison visitation policies differ regarding who can bring minor children to visit incarcerated parents, with some facilities requiring minor children be accompanied by biological parents or custodial guardians (Hairston, 2007). Considering the significant role that noncaregiving relatives may play in facilitating mother-child relationships and contact, implementing flexible visitation rules, such as allowing a non-guardian adult to accompany a child for visitation, may enable noncaregiving maternal relatives to coordinate prison visits.

Although prison systems have no influence on childcare arrangements, they can take steps to facilitate mother-child contact in ways that help reduce the burden on caregivers. To facilitate physical visits, prisons can provide transportation for children and families to visit incarcerated women, create family-friendly visiting spaces within the prison, and provide flexibility in visiting schedules and rules (Hairston, 2007; Mignon & Ransford, 2012; Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021). These efforts can alleviate the financial and, to some extent, physical burdens of travel for caregivers; for example, one participant highlighted that her mother's medical issues limited her ability to transport the children to the prison for contact visits. Moreover, these efforts can be especially important for women whose children live with paternal caregivers, who may be much less committed to maintaining the mother-child relationship. Prison-provided transportation may be the only opportunity these mothers have for face-to-face visits from children.

Although prisons can take steps to facilitate contact visits, additional efforts can be made to support alternative forms of communication. Prison facilities could provide access to email and videoconferencing software to enable more mother-child and mother-caregiver contact (Mignon & Ransford, 2012; although not available during the time of the interviews, the corrections facility where the interviews took place now provides videoconferencing opportunities between incarcerated women and their family members). These efforts can support mother-child relationships through direct contact and also reduce barriers to contact between mothers

and caregivers to allow more co-parenting to occur. In the context of alternative contact opportunities during COVID-19, researchers learned that although families prefer in-person contact visits, especially with younger children who may depend on physical interaction to facilitate bonding, accessible videoconferencing can provide additional contact between incarcerated mothers and their children (Dallaire et al., 2021). This can be especially important for mothers whose children live with paternal caregivers that may be less personally motivated to overcome obstacles to communicate with mothers or encourage mother–child communication.

In addition to supporting mother–child contact, prisons can also provide holistic family programming. Research suggests that incarcerated mothers (Koons-Witt et al., 2021) and their children (Johnson, 2012) value family programming, and such programming should extend to caregivers and/or maternal intermediaries (Baker et al., 2010; Cecil et al., 2008) and building stronger co-parenting alliances (Strozier et al., 2011). Parental incarceration often exacerbates already strained family dynamics (Brown, 2020), and including programming that begins in prison can allow mothers, their children, and kinship caregivers/maternal intermediaries to begin processing family trauma experienced before and during incarceration (Koons-Witt et al., 2021). The findings in this study suggest that mothers independently value their maternal caregiver relationships, and such programming might allow women to repair these important relationships and improve opportunities to co-parent. Moreover, research suggests that positive mother–caregiver relationships can protect against negative outcomes for children (Baker et al., 2010; Cecil et al., 2008; Denby, 2012; Strozier et al., 2011) and can have positive implications for families during reentry (Wilson & Koons-Witt, 2021).

Implications for family sciences

The findings of this study also have implications for parent and child educators and formal agencies who interact with families and children. Parent educators working with incarcerated mothers might formally encourage incarcerated women to repair and maintain relationships with maternal caregivers. Research suggests that parental education should support the overall development of clients as both persons and parents (Cooke, 2006), and fostering mother–maternal caregiver relationships that women already value as important could contribute to their overall personal growth and long-term success. Additionally, parent educators might assist mothers in identifying maternal relatives to facilitate their mother–child relationship during their incarceration. Although the findings from this study suggest that women may independently pursue these arrangements, formal discussion regarding maternal relatives who may act as an intermediary could serve to provide better support to incarcerated women’s parenting initiatives from prison. Creating and fostering these support networks with maternal caregivers and maternal intermediaries could have implications upon women’s return from prison. Best practices for parent education include helping parents establish prosocial networks (Cooke, 2006), and maternal caregivers and intermediaries willing to facilitate mother–child relationships during women’s incarceration would likely support mothers upon their reentry as well.

Findings from this study also have implications for formal agencies (e.g., schools, state welfare departments), including targeted interventions and increased information sharing. Although researchers have called for formal information sharing between agencies (Hanlon et al., 2007; McCormick et al., 2014), it would be useful also to include caregivers, mothers, and maternal intermediaries in information gathering and sharing. Schools can increase information gathering from their students (Brown, 2020), specifically collecting contact information on formal caregivers and maternal intermediaries, to keep both children’s formal caregivers and maternal intermediaries informed. Relatedly, increased information gathering would assist school counselors in identifying children with incarcerated mothers, allowing them to notify

involved teachers and implement appropriate interventions as needed (Brown, 2020; McCormick et al., 2014). When information sharing does occur across formal agencies, this information can be used to direct financial and other targeted support resources to current caregivers (Aiello & McQueeney, 2021; Denby, 2012), even those not formally recognized by the state family welfare system (Hanlon et al., 2007).

Limitations and future research

As with any project, several limitations exist within the study. First, although the interview includes questions that ask about mothers' relationships with caregivers and children, the current study design depends on one-time interviews with participants. Although the study attempted to capture how the relationships between mothers and their children may have changed over the course of their imprisonment, interviews at multiple points in time would have been able to capture changes more accurately over time in both these relationships.

Additionally, this study only included the perspectives of incarcerated mothers, without input from children or their caregivers. Research suggests that mothers and caregivers have differing views of the caregiving arrangement during a mother's incarceration (e.g., mothers report higher levels of parental involvement than do caregivers; Loper et al., 2014), and without including caregivers in this study, it is unknown how their perspectives may differ from those of incarcerated mothers. Relatedly, while scholars suggest that caregivers can impact the mother-child relationship in ways beyond providing (or preventing) co-parenting and contact opportunities (e.g., caregivers talking negatively or positively about incarcerated mothers to their children; McCormick et al., 2014), the findings from the current study are limited only to the experiences of incarcerated mothers. Therefore, it is likely that additional factors that are framing the mother-child-caregiver relationships are missing from the current study. Future research should explore other perspectives and factors by interviewing children with incarcerated mothers and the adults who care for them.

Finally, although this study was exploratory in nature and was not intended to provide generalizable results, it should be noted that these findings represent the experiences of only a few mother-caregiver dyads. About half of the women invited to participate declined to be interviewed, and it is possible that these women may have unique experiences that differ from the women who did participate in the study. Future qualitative work should continue to explore the experiences of incarcerated mothers, their children, and their children's caregivers, and quantitative approaches should be developed to better understand the pervasiveness of the findings presented here.

Conclusion

Incarcerated mothers tasked with finding care for their children during their prison term often face a difficult decision that has important implications for the relationships they have with their children and for their mothering experiences while incarcerated. Caregivers serve a vital role in that they not only assume responsibility for the care and custody of the children left behind in the community, but they also operate as a type of gatekeeper between children and their incarcerated mothers (Cunningham Stringer, 2020; Tasca, 2016). Caregivers can support and encourage the relationship between women and their children during her incarceration, or they can undermine that relationship by prohibiting contact and avoiding information sharing (Cunningham Stringer, 2020). The findings from this study suggest that whether caregiving arrangements include maternal or paternal relatives, they will undoubtedly shape mothers'

parenting experiences while in prison and ultimately the nature of the relationship mothers have with their children and other family members.

REFERENCES

- Aiello, B., & McQueeney, K. (2021). "Grandma is the next best thing to mommy": Incarcerated motherhood, caring relationships and maternal identity. *International Journal of Care and Caring*, 5(1), 105–128.
- Arditti, J., & Few, A. (2006). Mothers' reentry into family life following incarceration. *Criminal Justice Policy Review*, 17(1), 103–123.
- Baker, J., McHale, J., Strozier, A., & Cecil, D. (2010). Mother–grandmother coparenting relationships in families with incarcerated mothers. *Family Process*, 49(2), 165–184.
- Barnes, S. L., & Stringer, E. C. (2014). Is motherhood important? Imprisoned women's maternal experiences before and during confinement and their postrelease expectations. *Feminist Criminology*, 9(1), 3–23.
- Brown, E. C. (2020). School counselor conceptualizations of the needs of children of incarcerated parents. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 112, 1–9. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2020.104936>.
- Cecil, D. K., McHale, J., Strozier, A., & Pietsch, J. (2008). Female inmates, family caregivers, and young children's adjustment: A research agenda and implications for corrections programming. *Journal of Criminal Justice*, 36(6), 513–521.
- Christian, J. (2005). Riding the bus: Barriers to prison visitation and family management strategies. *Journal of Contemporary Criminal Justice*, 21(1), 31–48.
- Cooke, B. (2006). Competencies of a parent educator: What does a parent educator need to know and do? *Child Welfare*, 85(5), 785–802.
- Cooper-Sadlo, S., Mancini, M. A., Meyer, D. D., & Chou, J. L. (2019). Mothers talk back: Exploring the experiences of formerly incarcerated mothers. *Contemporary Family Therapy*, 41(1), 92–101. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10591-018-9473-y>.
- Cunningham Stringer, E. (2020). Managing motherhood: How incarcerated mothers negotiate maternal role-identities with their children's caregivers. *Women & Criminal Justice*, 30(5), 336–355.
- Dallaire, D. H., Shlafer, R. J., Goshin, L. S., Hollihan, A., Poehlmann-Tynan, J., Eddy, J. M., & Adalist-Estrin, A. (2021). COVID-19 and prison policies related to communication with family members. *Psychology, Public Policy, and Law*, 27(2), 231–241.
- Denby, R. W. (2012). Parental incarceration and kinship care: Caregiver experiences, child well-being, and permanency intentions. *Social Work in Public Health*, 27(1–2), 104–128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19371918.2012.639639>.
- Easterling, B. A., Feldmeyer, B., & Presser, L. (2019). Narrating mother identities from prison. *Feminist Criminology*, 14(5), 519–539.
- Enos, S. (2001). *Mothering from the inside: Parenting in a women's prison*. State University of New York Press.
- Fuller, L. (1993). Visitors to women's prisons in California: An exploratory study. *Federal Probation*, 57(4), 41–47.
- Glaze, L., & Maruschak, L. (2010). *Parents in prison and their minor children* (NCJ 222984). Bureau of Justice Statistics.
- Glesne, C. (2016). *Becoming qualitative researchers: An introduction*. Pearson.
- Hairston, C. F. (2007). *Focus on children with incarcerated parents: An overview of the research literature*. The Annie E. Casey Foundation. https://assets.aecf.org/m/resourcedoc/aecf-FocusonChildrenwith_ncarceratedParentsOverviewofLiterature-2007.pdf.
- Hanlon, T. E., Carswell, S. B., & Rose, M. (2007). Research on the caretaking of children of incarcerated parents: Findings and their service delivery implications. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 29(3), 348–362. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2006.09.001>.
- Harding, J. (2018). *Qualitative data analysis: From start to finish* (2nd ed.). Sage Publications.
- Johnson, B. J. (2016). Jail (e)mail: Free speech implications of granting inmates access to electronic messaging services. *Washington Journal of Law, Technology & Arts*, 11(4), 285–310.
- Johnson, T. (2012). Mapping the critical service needs of adolescent children of prisoners. *Social Work in Public Health*, 27(1/2), 45–68. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19371918.2012.629905>.
- Kiger, M. E., & Varpio, L. (2020). Thematic analysis of qualitative data: AMEE Guide No. 131. *Medical Teacher*, 42(8), 846–854. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0142159X.2020.1755030>.
- Koons-Witt, B., Huffman, A. C., & Wilson, A. (2021). Exploring the perceived helpfulness of correctional programs and needs among incarcerated mothers. *Journal of Offender Rehabilitation*, 60(8), 501–526. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10509674.2021.2000549>.
- Loper, A. B., Phillips, V., Nichols, E. B., & Dallaire, D. H. (2014). Characteristics and effects of the co-parenting alliance between incarcerated parents and child caregivers. *Journal of Child and Family Studies*, 23(2), 225–241. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-012-9709-7>.
- Mackintosh, V. H., Myers, B. J., & Kennon, S. S. (2006). Children of incarcerated mothers and their caregivers: Factors affecting the quality of their relationship. *Journal of Child and Family Studies*, 15(5), 581–596. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-006-9030-4>.

- Maruschak, L. M., Bronson, J., & Alper, M. (2021). *Parents in prison and their minor children* (NCJ 252645; Survey of Prison Inmates). Bureau of Justice Statistics.
- McCormick, A., Millar, H. A., & Paddock, G. B. (2014). In the best interests of the child: Strategies for recognizing and supporting Canada's at-risk population of children with incarcerated parents. *University of the Fraser Valley Centre for Safe Schools and Communities*. https://cjr.ufv.ca/wp-content/uploads/2015/05/Children-with-Incarcerated-Parents_Amended.pdf.
- Mignon, S. I., & Ransford, P. (2012). Mothers in prison: Maintaining connections with children. *Social Work in Public Health, 27*(1–2), 69–88.
- Miller, A. L., Perryman, J., Markovitz, L., Franzen, S., Cochran, S., & Brown, S. (2013). Strengthening incarcerated families: Evaluating a pilot program for children of incarcerated parents and their caregivers. *Family Relations, 62*(4), 584–596. <https://doi.org/10.1111/fare.12029>.
- Moe, A. M., & Ferraro, K. J. (2007). Criminalized mothers: The value and devaluation of parenthood from behind bars. *Women and Therapy, 29*(3–4), 135–164.
- Nesmith, A., & Ruhland, E. (2011). Caregivers of children with incarcerated parents. *The Open Family Studies Journal, 4*(1), 105–116.
- Pendleton, V. E., Schmitgen, E. M., Davis, L., & Schlafer, R. J. (2022). Caregiving arrangements and caregiver well-being when infants are born to mothers in prison. *Journal of Child and Family Studies, 31*(7), 1894–1907. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-021-02089-w>.
- Phillips, S., & Bloom, B. (1998). In whose best interest? The impact of changing public policy on relatives caring for children with incarcerated parents. *Child Welfare, 77*(5), 531–541.
- Poehlmann, J., Dallaire, D., Loper, A. B., & Shear, L. D. (2010). Children's contact with their incarcerated parents: Research findings and recommendations. *American Psychologist, 65*(6), 575–598.
- Poehlmann-Tynan, J. (2020). Reuniting young children with their incarcerated parents. *Zero to Three, 40*, 30–39.
- Ruiz, D. S., & Kopak, A. (2014). The consequences of parental incarceration for African American mothers, children, and grandparent caregivers. *The Journal of Pan African Studies, 7*(6), 9–24.
- Saldaña, J. (2016). *The coding manual for qualitative researchers* (3rd ed.). Sage Publications.
- Stringer, E. C., & Barnes, S. L. (2012). Mothering while imprisoned: The effects of family and child dynamics on mothering attitudes. *Family Relations, 61*(2), 313–326. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2011.00696.x>.
- Strozier, A. L., Armstrong, M., Skuza, S., Cecil, D., & McHale, J. (2011). Coparenting in kinship families with incarcerated mothers: A qualitative study. *Families in Society: The Journal of Contemporary Social Services, 92*(1), 55–61.
- Tasca, M. (2016). The gatekeepers of contact: Child-caregiver dyads and parental prison visitation. *Criminal Justice and Behavior, 43*(6), 739–758.
- Wilson, A., & Koons-Witt, B. (2021). “They still know I’m their momma”: Incarcerated mothers’ perceptions of reunification and resuming a caregiver role. *Feminist Criminology, 16*(5), 583–606. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1557085120983468>.
- Young, D. S., & Smith, C. J. (2000). When moms are incarcerated: The needs of children, mothers, and caregivers. *Families in Society, 81*(2), 130–141. <https://doi.org/10.1606/1044-3894.1007>.

How to cite this article: Wilson, A., Koons-Witt, B., & Pasquire, N. (2023). Mothering experiences in prison: Exploring distinctions between maternal and paternal caregiving arrangements. *Family Relations, 72*(5), 2754–2776. <https://doi.org/10.1111/fare.12807>